

A DEADLY DOSE

When medicine turns into poison

MADHYA PRADESH

THE VICTIMS

Since Sept. 2, 20 children have died in Chhindwara and Betul districts after consuming Coldrif syrup

Another nine children with similar kidney-related illnesses under treatment

THE CULPRITS

Coldrif is manufactured by Sresan Pharmaceuticals, based in Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu FDA found a batch adulterated with 48.6% diethylene glycol, a toxic industrial solvent

Production halted; owner S. Ranganathan and a govt paediatrician arrested



RAJASTHAN

THE VICTIMS

Four children died in Bharatpur and Sikar districts, families link it to govt-supplied dextromethorphan cough syrup

THE CULPRITS

State govt has banned all dextromethorphan syrups though rebutting charges

Suspended all medicine supplies from the Jaipur-based manufacturer, Kayson Pharma

PREVENTING FUTURE MISUSE

- When industrial-grade drums slip through without proper testing, toxic solvents enter paediatric formulations
- There is a need to enforce container-wise testing of all high-risk raw materials
- Strengthen state lab capacity and oversight
- Ensure centralised monitoring for all manufacturers, regardless of their size or location
- Make pre-release quality checks mandatory even for domestic batches
- Educate families and pharmacists on safe cough management

Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

base. Pharmaceutical-grade material is clean, but cheaper industrial-grade variants can carry DEG or EG. If a mislabelled or adulterated drum is accepted without container-wise testing, these toxins pass directly into paediatric formulations. "Patient safety is the non-negotiable cornerstone of the pharmaceutical sector," says Nikkhil K. Masurkar, CEO, Entod Pharmaceuticals. "Contamination with toxic solvents is the primary cause behind such fatal incidents." He calls for "a fundamental shift in mindset" with an "uncompromising focus on quality" from industry and regulators alike.

India's fragmented regulatory structure has long struggled with uneven oversight. As lawyer and *The Truth Pill* co-author Prashant Reddy notes, a 2013 amendment that could have strengthened CDSCO's export oversight was never passed, leaving outbound quality poorly policed. After the 2022 episodes, the Centre finally made a certificate of analysis from a government lab mandatory for each exported cough syrup batch. But exemptions soon followed. Its inadequacy showed up when a December 2023 CDSCO summary revealed that, of 2,000-plus syrups tested, 128 export-bound products from 54 firms had failed quality checks.

Crucially, that extra layer of testing applies only to exports. Domestic detection depends on manufacturers' inhouse checks and post-market sampling by state regulators—a system that often reacts only after harm occurs. Testing capacity is another weak link. The Central Drugs Testing Laboratories and SUGAM Labs portal bear the onus of oversight, but most enforcement rests with unevenly equipped state labs. Since December 2022, the health ministry's risk-based inspections have covered 905 units, triggering hundreds of enforcement actions—from stop-production orders to licence suspensions. Visible progress, yes—but still reactive.